

1683, and soon afterward founded Germantown with thirteen families of Creffelders, in all thirty-three persons. William Penn was present when the frame work of the first two-story house was built in Germantown, and partook of a Mennonite dinner at the "raising." Other immigrants began to arrive and the village of Germantown, then six miles from Philadelphia and now part of the city, became a prosperous settlement.

In 1719 another class of religionists whom Penn had invited to his province first landed in America and took up their abode with the Mennonites around Germantown. These people were the German Baptists, or Dunkers, who, in the main, held the same religious beliefs as the Mennonites and Quakers. They came to Germantown under the leadership of Christopher Sauer, a man of fine education, and who became the original publisher of German books in America.

A colony of eight families of Swiss Mennonites arrived at Holland, set sail for America, and in 1709 took up lands in the beautiful Pequea Valley, in Lancaster County, being the first white settlers to clear the lands and cultivate the soil of that region. They were the pioneers of a large immigration of these worthy people, who soon afterward occupied the fertile valleys immediately east of the Susquehanna. Having come to this province at the invitation of William Penn, these Swiss Mennonites lived peaceably with the Indians, who still had their villages along the Susquehanna and its tributary streams. They came under the leadership of John Herr, who has numerous descendants in the counties of Lancaster and York.

These people being pleased with their new surroundings in the primeval forests of Pennsylvania, decided to send the good tidings to their unfortunate friends in their native land. Martin Kendig was chosen to return to Europe, and the next year he came back to Pequea, the leader of a new band of Mennonites. In 1717 another band of Swiss Mennonites came to the Pequea Valley and settled themselves on lands surrounding those owned by their brethren who came before them. In 1726 a much larger immigration, to avoid religious perse-

cution in their native country, crossed the ocean and at last found a safe harbor in the land of Penn.

By the year 1732 there were several hundred of these people living in the fertile valleys of Lancaster County. In 1733, when the Blunston grants were given, permitting settlers to cross the Susquehanna, some of these Swiss Mennonites were among the earliest to locate in the limestone region east of York, and the fertile country of Heidelberg, Penn and the adjoining townships east and southeast of Hanover. They brought with them the Bible and other religious works from the Fatherland, and soon after their arrival founded a church in the vicinity of Menges' Mills, and one along the York Road, known as Bear's Meeting House, three miles southeast of Hanover. These settlements were made before the red men of the forests had given up these hunting grounds and moved westward ahead of the white emigration. The descendants of these early Mennonites still occupy the fertile lands taken up by their ancestors nearly two centuries ago.

THE GERMAN BAPTISTS.

The followers of Alexander Mack, founder of the German Baptist Church, began to settle in York County as early as 1738. One colony of these people took up the fertile lands in the southwestern portion of this county, settling there about the same time that the people of the Mennonite faith began to locate in that region. The Bermudian settlement, in the extreme western part of York County and the eastern part of Adams County, was composed almost entirely of German Baptists.

In colonial times there seems to have been three leaders among the German people in Pennsylvania. These persons were Christopher Sauer (Sower), the leader of the German Baptists, Michael Schlatter, a remarkable missionary among the German Reformed settlers, and Henry Melchoir Muhlenberg, one of the founders of the Lutheran Church in America. In many respects Christopher Sauer was the most progressive German in America in his day. He first settled on a farm in Lancaster County in 1724. He went to Germantown

Christopher Sauer.

in 1731, and in 1738 began to publish an almanac, which was widely circulated and exerted a powerful influence over the German people of Pennsylvania for more than half a century. It appeared every year from 1738 to 1798, the last numbers being published by his descendants. Sauer also began the publication of a religious and secular journal in 1739 and in 1743 he printed the first Bible which appeared from the press in America, except a portion of the Scriptures printed by Eliot at an earlier date, made for the Indians of Massachusetts. This edition of the Sauer Bible was limited to 1,200 copies. Two other editions were issued at a later date. Copies of the first edition are very rare. During his life time, Sauer published many books, and his printing house was continued by his descendants.

The Ephrata community, in Lancaster County, a body of Seventh Day Baptists, also followers of Alexander Mack, established a printing press in 1745 and published a large number of books in the German language. One of these, known as the "Martyr's Mirror," was the largest book printed in America before the Revolution.

Origin of the Church.

It may be interesting here to give the origin and early history of the German Baptist Church, their emigration to Pennsylvania and their settlement west of the Susquehanna.

The German Baptists, as a church body, originated in Germany in the year 1708. They usually call themselves "Brethren" and their church the "Brethren Church." They are sometimes called "Dunkers," from the German word "tunken," meaning to baptize or dip. This name originated in Pennsylvania during their early history here. They do not recognize the name Dunker, or Dunkard, as appropriate to designate their church body. The originators of this denomination in Germany met and held meetings among themselves for social worship, but the regular Protestant clergy soon caused the secular authorities to interfere. At this time, in 1695, a mild and lenient Count ruled over the province of Wigenstein, in North Prussia, where liberty of conscience was granted. To this place, although a poor, rough country, went many, who were aroused by a religious awakening and who desired to consult

among themselves as to church discipline and ecclesiastical polity. This province was soon known as "the rendezvous of the Lord's people." Those who collected there were first called Pietists, and all worshipped together. They then commenced to call themselves Brethren. One of the guiding points of their discipline was found in the book of Matthew, which says: "If thy brother trespass against thee, go and tell him his faults between thee and him alone." But to fulfill this injunction they needed some church order and they began to seek for the footsteps of the primitive Christians. The mystery of water baptism appeared to them a door of entrance into the true church, which they so earnestly sought, but they could not at once agree as to form. Finally, in 1708, eight of the most truth-loving of them agreed to enter into "a covenant of good conscience with God by taking up all the commandments of Jesus Christ as an easy yoke, and thus follow him as their faithful shepherd."

Those eight persons were George Graby and Lucas Vetter, from Hesse-Cassel; Alexander Mack, from Schriesheim, and his wife, Anna Margareta; Andrew Bonny, from Basle, Switzerland, and his wife, Johanna, and John Kipping, from Wurtemberg, and his wife, Johanna. These eight persons "covenanted and united as brethren and sisters of Jesus Christ," and thus formed the nucleus of a church of Christian believers. They claimed, after careful investigation, that according to the commands of Christ the primitive Christians "were planted into his death by a three-fold immersion in the water bath of holy baptism, being in exact harmony with the New Testament." Trine immersion was considered by them the only correct form of baptism. Being prepared for the ceremony of baptism, they went along the little stream called Aeder, in Germany, and he upon whom the labor had fallen baptized the leading brother and he in turn baptized the rest. In a few years there were large congregations gathered in Swartznau, in the Palatinate and in Marienborn. Persecution soon followed them. These unfortunate ones found refuge under the king of Prussia. Among the prominent workers in the church in Germany about 1715, some of whose descendants now live in York

County, were John Henry Kalclessor, of Frankenthal; Christian Liebe (Leib), of Ebstein; Johanna Nass (Noss), of Norten; Peter Becker, of Dillsheim; John Henry Trout and several brothers; Heinrich Holsapple and Stephen Koch, of the Palatinate.

This religious body suffered great persecutions in parts of the **Come to America.** Fatherland. Some fled to Cre-

felf, Prussia, from thence to Holland, thence to the province of Friesland, in the hope of finding an asylum of peace and safety, but were everywhere disappointed until they "turned their faces toward the land of Penn." where this entire religious body soon emigrated. Twenty families first emigrated, with Elder Peter Becker at their head, in 1719, and settled in the vicinity of Germantown, Pennsylvania. In 1729 thirty more families came over under the leadership of the celebrated Alexander Mack, who himself was a noted evangelist and a descendant of the Waldenses so well known to history. Settlements of them were soon formed at Skipack, Montgomery County, Oley, in Berks; and Conestoga, in Lancaster; all under the care of preachers Mack and Becker. In 1723 the church held a first election in America and chose Conrad Beissel, a minister, and John Hildebrand, a deacon, both to serve in Lancaster County. In the language of an old record, "Conrad Beissel got wise in his own conceit, had an idea that Saturday was the Lord's day, secured a number of followers, and in 1729 organized, at Ephrata, the German Seventh-day Baptists," who were afterward known as a distinct church body. In 1732 Beissel organized a monastic society at Ephrata. The churches at Ephrata, at Conestoga, and one in Chester County attracted so many settlers that land became high. So numerous members of the Brethren Church, as early as 1736, began to migrate to what is now York County. Some went down into Maryland.

The first church in York **Conewago Church.** County by the Brethren was organized in 1738, "twenty miles west from the town of York, on the Little Conewago." This was in the vicinity of Hanover. The district embraced by the church included a large extent of territory east, north and northwest

of the site of the present town of Hanover. It will thus be seen that the German Baptists were among the earliest people to form church organizations in York County.

Among the early members who organized this church, in 1738, were Eldrick, Dierdorff, Bigler, Gripe, Studsman and others. Among the prominent members of this congregation in 1770 were Jacob Moyer and James Henrick, preachers; Hans Adam Snyder, George Wine, Daniel Woods, Henry Geing, Joseph Moyer, Nicholas Hostetter, Christian Hostetter, Rudy Brown, Dobis Brother, Jacob Miller, **Michael Koutz**, Stephen Peter, Henry Tanner, Michael Tanner, John Moyer, **Jacob Souder**, Henry Hoff, John Swartz. The wives of all these persons named were also members of this church. The unmarried members were Barbara Snyder, John Geing, Maud Bowser, George Peter, Hester Wise, Christian Etter, John Peter Weaver, Barbara Bear, Elizabeth Boering, Grace Hymen.

Their first preacher was Daniel Leatherman, Senior. He was followed by Nicholas Martin, Jacob Moyer (Meyers), James Hendrich (Henry), etc.

In 1741 there was another church organized in the limits of what was then York County, "on the Great Conewago, about fourteen miles west from the new town of York." This was the same year York was founded. Many of the members of the church lived in the present territory of Adams County, in the vicinity of the villages of **Abbottstown** and East Berlin. Among the first members of this organization were John Neagley, **Adam Sower**, Jacob Sweigard, Peter Neiper and Joseph Latshaw. Their first elder was George Adam Martin, who was followed by Daniel Leatherman, Jr., and Nicholas Martin. The following were the members in 1770: George Brown, preacher; John Heiner, Peter Fox, Anthony Dierdorff, Nicholas Moyer, Manasseh Brough, Michael Bosserman, David Ehrhard, Daniel Baker, Abraham Stauffer, Henry Dierdorff, John Burkholder, Andrew Trimmer, Eustace Rensel, Peter Dierdorff, Barnett Augenbaugh, John Neagley, Michael Brissel, Welty Brissel, Matthias Bouser, Laurence Baker, Philip Snell, Nicholas Baker, Jr., **Adam Sower**, Adam Dick, Henry Brissel, David Brissel, Henry Radibush, George Wagner,

George Reeson, and their wives. The unmarried members were Peter Wertz, Ann Mummert, Christian Fray, Samuel Arnold, Mary Latshaw, Catherine Studabaker, Nicholas Baker, Marillas Baker, Sarah Brissel, Jacob Miller, Rudolph Brown. The two organizations already described were known as the Conewago Churches.

Bermudian Church. There was another congregation organized within the present area of Washington Township, "fifteen miles from the town of York," called the Bermudian Church. The first constituents of this organization separated from the Cloister Church, at Ephrata, Lancaster County, in 1735, and organized in 1738 in York County. Many of them were Seventh-day Baptists. The church was considered an offspring of Ephrata, but for a while they worshipped with the Brethren. Some of the founders of it were: Philip Gebel, Peter Beissel, Henry Lowman, Peter Miller and George Adam Martin.

Some of the prominent persons who composed its membership in 1770 were: Frederick Reuter and wife, Daniel Fahnestock and wife, Peter Henry and wife, Paul Troub and wife, Dietrich Fahnestock and wife, John Cook and wife, Peter Bender and wife, Melchoir Webber and wife, John Lehr and wife, John Messerbach and wife, George Reiss (Rice) and wife, George Neiss (Nace) and wife, Benjamin Gebel (Gable) and wife, Philip Beissel and wife, Baltzer Smith and wife, Widows Dorothy and Stauffer, several families by the name of Frick, from whom descended Henry C. Frick, of Pittsburgh; John Bentz, wife, daughter, and four sons; John Miller, wife, and two sons; Peter Beissel, wife, son, and two daughters. This list includes both Seventh-day Baptists and Brethren. Later in the history of the church the Seventh-day Baptists, or "Sieben Tager," as they were called, maintained a separate organization, but as a church ceased to exist in this county about 1820. Some of the members about that time were Frederick Reider, Jacob Kimmel, Michael Kimmel, John Meily, Samuel, Daniel, and Boreas Fahnestock, and others.

The Codorus Church. The "Codorus Church was organized in the Township of Codorus, eleven miles southeast of York, in 1758," and soon after

numbered in its membership about forty families. The first elder of this church was Jacob Danner, a son of Michael Danner, a prominent man in the early history of the county and one of the five commissioners appointed to view and lay off York County in 1749. Jacob Danner, Heinrich Danner and their father were among the most intelligent of the first German emigrants west of the Susquehanna, and figured very prominently in their day. Jacob Danner was a poet of no mean reputation. About the year 1750 he and Rev. Jacob Lischy, of York Reformed Church, engaged in a vigorous religious controversy. The manuscripts containing Danner's arguments were written in verse in his native German language. Jacob Danner moved to Frederick County, Md. The controversy showed considerable ability on the part of both clergymen.

Prominent among the first members of the Codorus congregation, in 1758, were Rudy Yunt, Peter Brillharth, John Brillharth, Henry Neff and wife. After Jacob Danner went to Maryland, Henry Neff was called to the ministry and remained pastor until after 1775. He was highly appreciated by his people, and kept careful official records. Some of the other members of this church, in 1770, were Jacob Tillman, wife and daughter; Jacob Spitler, wife and two daughters; Jacob Neiswanger and wife, Anna Neiswanger, and Elizabeth Seip, George Beary and wife, John Harold and wife, William Spitler and wife, Christian Eby, Wendell Baker and wife, Michael Berkey and wife, George Etter and son, Matthias Sitler and wife, Susanne Weltner, Catherine Beightley.

The celebrated Baptist preacher, Morgan Edwards, of Philadelphia, visited his Dunker Brethren in York County in 1770 and afterward wrote an interesting report of their prosperity here.

Being non-resistants in principle and in church discipline, the first who emigrated to York County had no difficulties with the Indians. During the Revolution most of them took the oath of allegiance.

"The annual conference was held first in York County in 1789 on the Great Conewago." The following named elders or bishops were present: Daniel Leatherman, Martin Urner, Jacob Danner, Heinrich